

Peers-Observing-Peers

Structured peer observation to reveal real behaviour

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Peers-Observing-Peers is a research method in which members of a target community observe and document each other's behaviour, capturing candid, in-context actions that outsiders or self-reports would miss. It leverages insider access and trust.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A participatory-research method embedded in design toolkits such as the HPI/Stanford-derived *Design Thinking Toolbox*.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

People behave differently when watched by outsiders and misreport their own habits. Peer observation reduces observer effects and reaches settings researchers cannot access.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

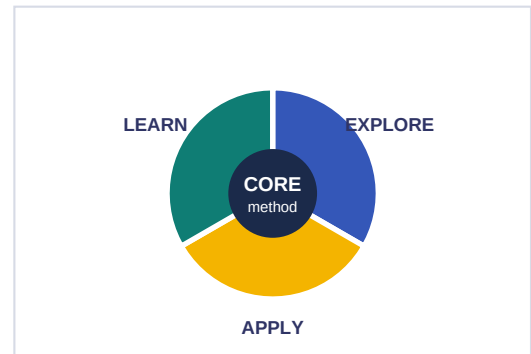


Figure 1. Peers-Observing-Peers framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

HOW IT IS USED

Recruit and brief community members, give them a light observation guide, collect their notes and artefacts, then synthesise with the design team.

WHEN IT IS USED

Empathy phase, especially for private, sensitive or hard-to-access contexts.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Design researchers and teams doing community-based or participatory research.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It extends observation into spaces researchers **cannot ethically or practically enter**, complementing AEIOU and empathy interviews.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

AEIOU *Slibrary 5*

Empathy Map *Slibrary 5*

Persona / User Profile *Slibrary 5*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

IDEO (2015) *The Field Guide to Human-Centered Design*. San Francisco: IDEO.org.